child of mars

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/58627306.

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Mature

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, Rape/Non-Con, Underage

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Castaspella & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra)

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by Morag

Summary

Catra folds slow and careful, and by the time Ms. Torres helps her bloom out the crane's wings, her heart beats quiet.

"I love it," Ms. Torres tells her, and it has to be a lie like it always is. Catra wants to believe it anyway.

Notes

I thought I had laid this series to rest, but then Paganaidd's excellent *Polaris* reminded me of a bunch of flashback scenes that were cut for time and things I had wanted to do in the series that never made it. So. Here we are. Some of the events of this fic come from *Polaris* and I want to make sure credit is given where it's due. You absolutely should read that first if you haven't already. Thank you to Paganaidd for both the excellent companion to this series and for inspiring me to come back to it.

If you've read the rest of the series, you know what content warnings there are (and they're all in the tags). No new ones here. If you haven't, I'm not sure how much sense this fic is going to make.

See the end of the work for more notes

- Inspired by Polaris by Paganaidd

Chapter 1

Kindergarten, August

Five years, six months

"Catra and Adora," the teacher says, again. Some boy in a red shirt giggles. "What are we supposed to have while other people are talking?"

Adora sits up straighter next to Catra. She'd been wiggly all morning, even more than usual, and last night she kicked so much that Catra woke her up to tell her to stop it before she kicked Catra over the railing. "Quiet mouths and listening ears," Adora says, pink in her cheeks.

Catra's quiet mouth doesn't say that this is all stupid. Her brain keeps sliding off whatever that dumb kid is saying about his summer, and she just wants to look at all the books lined up against the wall instead of squinting across the room.

The teacher thanks that kid for sharing (Louis, apparently) and then the next one goes. It's going to take forever to get to her and Adora, and they didn't go to camp or on a plane or to the beach, so they won't even have anything to say. They only went to-

"That's the book from daycare," Catra whispers to Adora, pointing at the princess book Adora likes. She likes the horses in it best. Daycare only had two books with horses in them, but kindergarten is supposed to be better, so maybe they have more. "Maybe later-"

"Kennedy and Adora," the teacher says, "we're going to trade seats."

Catra stands up too. "Catra," the teacher says, "you stay there. You and Adora can't be respectful listeners if you're next to each other."

No. Since the moment Ms. Weaver told them they'd be in the same class - *where, Adora, I expect you to keep her under control* - Catra knew she had to stay next to Adora. When Catra crashed into Adora's bed after her punishment yesterday, Adora hugged her and said that school would be okay as long as they stayed together, and the bright spots popping in Catra's eyes after hours in the dark didn't even matter.

"We're sorry." Adora holds Catra's hand back when Catra grabs it. "We'll fix it, I promise! We'll listen!"

"You'll listen from Kennedy's seat today," the teacher says.

Catra tightens her hold when Adora steps away. Adora pulls harder, whispers, "Catra-"

"No!" Catra shouts at the teacher. She probably told the class her name. Stupid awful dumbfaces don't need names, or inside voices.

Adora twists out of her grip. "Stop it and be good," Adora whispers, before she starts to walk away.

Catra grabs the pencil cup and hurls it at the ground, and the loud crack isn't close to loud enough.

Everyone goes away from her, then, when she falls apart into a tornado of fists and teeth. She throws anything she can reach, kicks the desk hard enough to send lightning up her leg, screams until she has to gasp instead. Someone picks her up and traps her hands to carry her away.

"Let me fucking go!" she tells at whoever's taking her, but if they answer, she can't hear it.

They get halfway down the hall before it hits that she's in trouble. She doesn't want to go to the director's office and sit on the floor and wait for Ms. Weaver to come, so all the teachers can tell her why Catra's a feral brat that's too awful to be around the other

kids. Ms. Weaver said she'd be too bad for school, and she was right. All of her fight empties out, then.

Catra's put down on a bean bag, soft, fuzzy. The hairs stick to her wet face.

"Hey," a voice says. "Your name's Catra, right?"

Catra curls away, cries instead of answering. She wants Adora. She wouldn't've been bad if her teacher had just let her stay with Adora.

"Can you help me with something?" There's something plastic by her hand, and she lifts her head enough to squint at it. "I'm looking for a fish." The bottle's full of blue sprinkles, but Catra can see a purple tentacle sticking out of the grains. "Can you help me find it?"

The voice is calm. Daycare teachers are always busy, and Ms. Milagros is always in a hurry, and Ms. Weaver is angry or mean or sick of her. Adora's the only person who's ever calm to her.

The bottle turns. Catra likes the sound it makes, a quiet rustle. "See," someone says, "that's the lobster there. Do you see the fish? It's orange."

Catra sniffs and follows the hand holding the bottle up to a woman, younger than her teacher. Her black hair is up in a bun. She must not be whoever carried Catra in here, because she isn't mad.

"Hi," the woman says, and Catra takes the bottle out of her hands before the woman realizes that she needs to hold on tighter. Catra only needs to shake it twice to find the flicker of orange in the blue.

Catra points to it, and the woman smiles. Almost every adult Catra's seen today has smiled at her, because she was using her walking feet and quiet mouth and holding Adora's gentle hand.

The woman says, "Good job! Are you feeling better?"

They're not in a regular classroom - there's only one table, and the few chairs are covered in bright fur. Catra's eyes dart to see if the door's open. It's not. It might not be locked, but it probably is, especially now that Catra's proven that she's too wild to be with the normal kids. Ms. Weaver said they'd kick her out of school if she can't behave. Catra doesn't want to be stuck at home with the dark and the belt forever.

"Are you the director?" Catra asks. She bit the inside of her cheek earlier, and her mouth tastes like blood.

"I'm Ms. Torres," the woman says. "I help kids calm down."

Adora tells Catra to calm down a lot. She's not good at that.

Ms. Torres pats a clear plastic tub on the table. "Come check out my rice bin. I just did the colors yesterday."

Catra comes to the table, but she doesn't touch the rainbow in the box, as much as she wants to. "When is she coming to get me?"

"Your mother?"

Ms. Weaver isn't her mother, and she doesn't want to be, but that's what everyone calls her anyway, so Catra nods.

"You didn't hurt anyone," Ms. Torres said, "so we would like you to stay at school so you can keep learning. But no one can learn when you're yelling and throwing things, friend."

Catra keeps her arms over her stomach, in case Ms. Torres decides she's mad. None of the daycare teachers hit, but school might be different.

"So Ms. Bell asked me to bring you here and calm down, and then you can go back to kindergarten to apologize and get a fresh start." Ms. Torres stirs a corner of the rainbows. "Everyone's first day is hard. We're going to reset and try again, okay?"

The rice rustles under Catra's fingers. Ms. Torres shows her how to breathe like she's smelling flowers and blowing out candles, and she says Catra's really smart when she does it by herself. Catra feels closer to okay with every breath, even though Adora isn't here.

Catra makes it back to her classroom with enough time for apologies before read-aloud. Adora pauses next to her before the teacher assigns carpet squares and whispers, "Where did you go?"

Catra picks a grain of purple rice out from under her fingernail. "Somewhere nice."

Kindergarten, March

Six years, one month

The shoes stop in front of the door of the end stall, where Catra's squeezed between the toilet and the wall.

"Honey," Ms. Torres' voice says. "Please come out."

Catra pulls back tighter against the tile. Her stomach is raw and ragged, like the monster ripped out one of the colorful blobs that should be there. Her wet clothes are cold.

"No one's mad at you," Ms. Torres lies. She lies all the time, especially when she tells Catra that she's smart and creative and helpful.

The door rattles when Ms. Torres crawls under the door. She slides the lock back to open the door before she crouches again. "Let's go, friend," she says, holding out a full plastic bag. "Ms. Bell has clothes for you, you can change."

Yesterday in the basement, when Catra said *no, no, stop, it hurts,* the shadows told her to shut up. Now, no sound comes out of her. Maybe she used it up.

"I know it feels like a big deal," Ms. Torres says, "but Catra, kids have accidents all the time. It's okay. Everyone understands."

Catra shakes her head, hard enough to make her stomach flip. Her knees stay up to her chest, even though it hurts, even though it won't help.

Words slip out of her mouth. "Am I going home?"

Ms. Torres' eyebrow furrows, and if Catra could move she'd shove her head away, make her stop looking. "Do you want to?"

"No," Catra whispers, quiet enough that maybe the shadows can't hear her.

"Okay, then." Ms. Torres holds out the bag again. "Let's get changed so we can go somewhere more comfortable."

Catra gets as far as the hem of her shirt before she freezes. The shadows don't make her do it herself. She thinks about Ms. Torres crowding in on her and she blinks so she doesn't start crying again.

"If you don't need help, I'll be outside," Ms. Torres says. She closes the door like she says she will.

Catra's quick. She doesn't have to look at everything that hurts if it's under her clothes. The shirt Ms. Bell gave her has a butterfly on it, splashed rainbow, smooth. She traces it with her fingers while Ms. Torres tells her that she can't run out of the classroom again, that she could have gotten really hurt, that she scared Ms. Bell.

"Everyone wants you to be safe," Ms. Torres says, and Catra digs a nail into the paint across her stolen shirt. She wonders if she's dead. She wonders if she'd know if she was.

Adora rubs her hands together at recess. "We can play whatever you want," she says, nerves in her voice. "You pick."

Catra's borrowed jeans pinch. Yesterday they sat in the tunnel in the playground equipment, because Catra was too sore and tired to run, and the plastic rattled when Adora fidgeted. "Play with somebody else," Catra says.

"I don't want to." Adora reaches for her hand and Catra pulls back before she gets there. "You're my best friend, I want to be with you. We could-"

The sludge in Catra's chest turns to lava in an instant. She shoves Adora away, and Adora hits the ground hard. "Just go away!"

Adora frowns at her as she gets up. "Why-"

"Shut up!" Catra's hands are fists and her voice is a siren. "I said go away!"

Behind Adora, Gabbie runs towards Ms. Bell, who's already looking. Catra's going to be in trouble *again* and it's stupid Adora's stupid fault. When Adora grabs her arm, Catra hits her with all the rage she has, but Adora doesn't let go.

Catra punches her again, and Adora makes a sound like it hurts. Catra's throat hurts when she yells. "Leave me alone!"

Adora finally steps back, face scrunched like she's crying or she's going to. Ms. Bell is calling Catra's name. Now she'll have to go home, and Ms. Bell will tell Ms. Weaver why she's wearing someone else's clothes, and she'll get punished for that too.

Catra crawls under the slide and keeps screaming even when her ears and voice and chest ache. When Ms. Torres ducks under the top of the slide, Catra's coughing more than shouting.

"Hey, can you come help me with something?" Ms. Torres asks, as if Catra doesn't know she's taking her home.

"No," Catra grinds through her raw throat. "'M not going."

"It's the rules, my friend. You can't hurt people at school, no matter who they are." Ms. Torres puts out her hand. "You can walk with me, or I can carry you."

The rest of the class is gone when Catra walks to the decompression room. Ms. Weaver is already there, anger spilling off her in waves, and Catra's feet stick instead of running the way she wants to.

"I'm so sorry about her," Ms. Weaver tells Ms. Torres. She always sounds tired when she talks to other grown-ups. She holds Catra's wrist tight, and worms squirm under Catra's skin. "You should see her at home. Between the tantrums and the regression, this one's going to kill me."

"She's having a difficult time right now, but we'll get through it." Ms. Torres bends down to look at Catra. "I'll see you tomorrow, okay? We'll try again."

When Catra doesn't answer, Ms. Weaver squeezes her wrist. "Tell your teacher `Thank you,'" she says.

Catra can't find the words when she looks for them. Ms. Weaver's grip crushes. "It's okay," Ms. Torres says before Ms. Weaver can speak. "We'll see you tomorrow, friend."

After the car door slams shut, Ms. Weaver snaps, "If I *ever* get another call about you attacking Adora, I'll make sure your body is never found. Do you understand?"

If Catra looks out at the school, she doesn't have to see the angry face. She can't find the stars that Ms. Bell put on her classroom windows.

"Answer me."

Catra nods, and it must be good enough because then the car starts, and the school slides away.

First grade, October

Six years, eight months

Ms. Torres shouldn't be at the door. Catra's sitting in her seat, and participating, and she's keeping her hands to herself. She's back at school and she wants to stay here.

"I have to borrow Catra for a little bit," Ms. Torres tells Ms. Layton. "About the-" she gestures vaguely.

Ms. Layton nods and waves for Catra to come over. Adora stands up, hands planted on the table. "She didn't do anything!"

Catra always did something. On the rainbow chart against the wall, the clip with her name starts every day on the green square with everyone else, but everything she does makes it drop down the colors until it clings to the red at the bottom. That square says *Make Better Choices*, because Catra only makes bad ones. Adora doesn't get it because her clip lives up on *Super Student.*

"She's not in trouble," Ms. Torres says. "I promise. I'll bring her back when she's done."

The halls are empty. "Your social worker's here to talk to you," Ms. Torres says. "You remember her, right?"

Ms. Milagros comes to the house sometimes, asks a few questions, looks at the room Catra shares with Adora. Mostly she talks to Ms. Weaver. Even when she has to drive Catra all the way to the prison for visits with her mom, they don't really talk.

She's never come to school before, though. "Why is she here?" Catra asks.

"She'll tell you," Ms. Torres says, oddly stiff. She holds Catra's hand in the hall a little firmer than usual. "You just have to tell her the truth. It'll be okay."

Ms. Milagros is in Ms. Torres' chair, little computer out on the curved table. "Catra," she says, barely looking up. "I have a few questions."

Ms. Torres pauses by the door. "Should I..."

"I'll take it from here." Ms. Milagros taps on her keyboard. "This won't take long."

The door closes behind Ms. Torres when she leaves. Catra's never seen Ms. Milagros without Ms. Weaver on the other end of the couch. Catra climbs into the blue chair, pulling up her legs under her. There are grains of rice hidden in the fur where another kid must have spilled it.

"You weren't at school yesterday, right?" Ms. Milagros asks.

Now Catra knows why she's here. The fading bruise on her cheek throbs. Ms. Weaver slammed open the basement door yesterday, furious, *You're not stupid enough to tell Adora what a sick fuck you are, are you? What the hell did you tell her? Don't make me pry it-*

"Focus."

"Adora's a liar," Catra says, squinting through the stinging in her eyes.

"We'll get to that. Were you here or not?"

Ms. Weaver helped her practice what Catra was going to say to Ms. Layton, and now she tells Ms. Milagros the same thing. She was home sick from school, she fell on the playground over the weekend, she's better now. "It doesn't even hurt anymore," she says. Her tongue keeps catching on the new sharp edge where her tooth chipped.

"Okay." Ms. Milagros angles her laptop away. "Adora told a story at school yesterday, and I'm going to talk to her about that, because she wasted time that I could have spent helping kids who actually need it. I hope you didn't feed her that lie."

"No." Catra fists her hands in the fuzzy fabric of the chair. Her stomach knots.

"Good." Ms. Milagros sighs. "I have so many kids with issues, Catra, and I constantly have to move them. I'm sure it feels like things aren't fair sometimes, but Ms. Weaver is trying to prepare you for the world. She's making you strong. You're lucky."

Catra doesn't feel lucky, or strong. She feels like a bug that squishes out red guts on the asphalt.

"You'll understand when you're older." Ms. Milagros folds her laptop closed. "Now, show me where your classroom is, so I can talk to Adora and close this case out."

Ms. Torres is in the hallway, talking to a kid standing with a different para. "Oh," she says, eyebrows jumping. "Done already!"

"Just red tape," Ms. Milagros says, whatever that means. "Everything's fine."

Ms. Torres walks Catra back to Ms. Layton's room. "How are you?" Ms. Torres asks. Her smile looks forced.

"Good." Catra bats at a loose piece of border on a bulletin board as they pass, and Ms. Torres doesn't tell her to stop like she usually does.

Adora's face is blotched red when she comes back to the classroom later. Ms. Torres doesn't *look* angry when she talks to Ms. Layton in a voice too quiet to hear, but Catra can sense it. When it's free choice, Catra stops at the classroom library before going to Adora's table. Adora's head is down on the plastic like it hurts. Catra reads through all four horse books the library has,

making up the words when she can't sound them out, until the lines on Adora's face smooth.

First Grade, February

Seven years

"What's up over there?"

Catra blinks. Her hand cramps around the plastic doll's legs. The smaller one on the floor has a dent on its head that wasn't there before.

Ms. Torres had work to do, so she was being nice by letting Catra play with Ms. Bell's toys from the kindergarten room while the rest of the lower school was at the aquarium. She did Catra a favor, and now Catra's ruining it like she ruins everything.

Ms. Torres sits down next to her. "Heard you using a hammer. Are you building the house?"

Catra shakes her head.

A small crease forms between Ms. Torres' eyebrows as she looks over the kitchen. "Are they getting ready to eat?"

"They're having dinner." Catra sweeps the bad doll down the stairs. Her fingers uncurl slow around the big one so she can put her on a chair. "Spaghetti."

"Oh," Ms. Torres says, turning the doll at the bottom of the stairs to sit up. "This friend needs to be more careful."

"That's the bad one." Catra straightens the blonde girl where she slid in her seat. "She can eat when she's good, but she never is."

She can feel Ms. Torres watching her. Then Ms. Torres makes the doll stand up, tap up the stairs. "I feel so much better now!" she says, in a stupid high-pitched voice that's nowhere near right. "Spaghetti sounds-"

"No!" Catra grabs the doll out of Ms. Torres' hand before she makes it worse. "You're doing it wrong!"

The toy cracks on the plastic wall when Catra throws her back where she belongs. "The brat's in trouble," Catra says, hard enough to make her teeth hurt. "She has to stay there forever. That's what bad ones get."

She has to fix the mom and the girl again. They keep leaning in their chairs. The plates shifted on the table when the house rattled.

"What about her friend?" Ms. Torres asks, gesturing to the toy next to the bad doll. "Maybe they can help each other."

"The shadow monster isn't a friend," Catra says, and her annoyed fingers knock the girl's chair over. "It's mean. It hurts."

Ms. Torres pauses. "Can you tell me about it?"

"It has something on its face." Catra puts her hands in front of her face, with gaps where the eyes should be. "Like this, but red. And it lives in the basement. It makes the shadows hold you down, and-"

Her voice stops like it's been unplugged. Ms. Torres likes her, she listens, she's nice. Tense angry static is growing in the air, and Ms. Torres is going to be even more mad if she knows how awful Catra really is, what she deserves. Thinking about Ms. Torres' hands over her mouth and under her clothes makes Catra want to die.

Catra pulls all three dolls out so she can start over. Ms. Torres asks her something else, but she shakes her head instead of listening.

As soon as the big doll knocks the bad one down, Ms. Torres picks up the dollhouse and says, "Let's play with something else."

Ms. Torres gives her the coloring book and tells her she can pick which pages to make copies of. Catra makes sure to include a few horses for Adora, and she works on one while Ms. Torres types on her computer across the table. Ms. Torres keeps frowning at her computer, so Catra colors a kangaroo for her when she's done with Adora's horse. She's careful, and the crayons stay in the lines, even in the little details of the baby in the pouch.

Ms. Torres sticks the kangaroo on the magnet board. When the buses pull up in the parking lot, she smooths a gold star on the back of Catra's hand, like the ones that Adora gets on her worksheets when she gets all the answers right.

"Why?" Catra asks.

"For being my helper today," Ms. Torres said. "I'm really proud of you."

Catra manages to hide the sticker from the bus to her bedroom, where she sticks it to one of the wooden slats holding up Adora's bed. It glints in the moonlight, edges peeling, before she closes her eyes. Later, Adora changes the sheets while Catra cleans herself up, and Adora nestles into her side under the blankets like Catra isn't a repulsive little shit.

"I like your star," Adora mumbles, sleepy again already.

The cold water from the bathtub faucet made Catra too awake. "I was good today, I guess."

"You're always good," Adora lies, before her muscles soften into sleep. Catra leans her head on Adora's and thinks about kangaroo babies, warm in their pouches.

Chapter 2

Second grade, September

Seven years, seven months

"Jesus!" the woman holding her says, when Catra's thrashing legs hit something hard. Catra doesn't know her name. She just knows it's not Ms. Torres. "For the last time, chill out."

Catra won't chill out. Her stomach still aches from missing dinner, and she's still sore where the thing in the mask hurt her, and she can't see Adora until recess, so when Lewis told Catra to stop pushing in the breakfast line, Catra tackled him. She already heard the other para call home, all apologies, *so sorry, yes, again.*

Catra wants to break her hands on the teacher's face, pull out her teeth, carve deep cuts in her stomach until she finally understands how angry Catra is. They're in the decompression room, but Ms. Torres isn't. She's supposed to be here.

Catra kicks again, and the para that called Ms. Weaver pins her legs down. The one who wants Catra to chill out traps her wrists in one hand and braces her head with the other. Catra tries to turn her head and bite, but they're too strong, like Ms. Weaver and the shadows are too strong, like everyone is stronger and better than she is.

"When you said this one gets agitated," the para holding her legs says, looking past Catra like she doesn't exist, "you weren't kidding. I'm glad Casta usually takes her, woman's a saint."

"She's naive," the one behind her says. "She'll grow out of that."

The shadows got here early - Catra can feel them slither on her skin. She sobs instead of breathing.

"Calm down, kid," someone tells her. "Can't let you go until you're calm."

Catra can't, useless. She doesn't deserve Ms. Torres here, because she's a nightmare and she's going to die.

"Delia said she freaked out because she had to wait in line."

The woman on her legs tightens her grip when Catra's body jerks. "Kids these days are so spoiled. If their parents weren't too soft to swat 'em, we wouldn't be dealing with this."

Catra's nose drips over her lip as she cries. Ms. Torres always lets her go when she stops fighting, but Ms. Torres isn't here. She hates Catra and wants her to go home and get eaten.

Catra can't see the door open, but she can hear it, and thinking about Ms. Weaver's angry face makes her head hurt worse. She hears Ms. Torres' voice, though. "I've got her," Ms. Torres says, grasping Catra's hands. "It's okay. I'll take her from here."

After everyone else leaves, Ms. Torres lets her go. Catra drags her sleeve over her face. The tears won't stop.

"What's going on, friend?" Ms. Torres asks, like she always does, like she gives a shit.

Catra's supposed to be calm. She's growling instead. "You weren't here."

Ms. Torres breathes in, out. "I had to help someone else, Catra. Other kids have bad days too."

Kids have bad days. Monsters are bad all the time, and there's only one adult who ever pretends to care how she feels. It shouldn't hurt because she doesn't deserve help and she doesn't need it anyway.

Ms. Torres crouches. "Catra, look at me," Ms. Torres says, and Catra doesn't. "If I could've been here, I would have."

The phone on the wall rings, and Catra's done this enough times to know who's here. She's going to throw up. "Don't want to go

home," she says around the sharp edges in her throat.

"I know, I'm sorry," Ms. Torres says, and she sounds sorry. "But you can't hurt people at school, Catra. There are rules."

Catra wants to promise that she'll never do it again, she'll listen, she'll behave. The last time she said that, Ms. Weaver said *keep arguing with me and-*

"Please," Catra chokes out. "Please, let me stay, Ms. Torres, please, I don't-"

The phone rings again, and Ms. Torres steps away to pick it up. Catra darts to the corner, between the radiator and the wall, where there's just enough space for her. She jams herself in, angling her shoulders to fit, pulling up her legs to cover her sore ribs. Ms. Torres is looking now, saying something into the phone that Catra can't hear over her heart pounding.

Ms. Torres hangs up and crouches on the floor, far enough away that Catra can't reach if she kicks. "Catra," she says. "I sent your, um, guardian to go get your things, but-"

"No!" Catra's arms can't reach her face, the way she's hiding. "Don't - don't make me-"

"Honey, I can't-"

The door opens and Catra can feel the anger from here. She closes her eyes so she can't see the angry too.

"Thank you, Casta," Ms. Weaver says. There's a steel thread of frustration under her tone. "I apologize for her behavior, again. She had to go up to the prison last weekend, and it always makes her worse."

Catra shoves away the memory of her mom's fingers tracing circles on the metal table, like Catra does when she's nervous. Her mom wouldn't try to make Catra like her if she could see her howl, writhe like a worm dying on the sidewalk, disgusting.

"That's a difficult situation for any kid," Ms. Torres says, and she doesn't sound like she does when she talks to Catra. Her voice is weird and cold.

"God only knows what that woman did to her." Ms. Weaver's voice gets closer, and Catra presses against the wall. "Of course seeing her again is too much for the poor thing."

A hand closes over Catra's wrist, and Catra cries harder. Ms. Weaver pulls with the sharpness that means *don't make me tear this fucking thing off.*

Catra's shoulders scrape on the radiator, and she's standing, wrist held tight. All of her desperate words have dried up.

Ms. Torres drops to one knee to see her better and says, "Catra, we'll see you on Thursday, okay? Have a good two days. We'll be missing you."

Catra's already missing, huge chunks of her gone. Ms. Weaver shakes her arm, but Catra doesn't say goodbye.

"We're working on her manners," Ms. Weaver tells Ms. Torres.

Catra comes back the next week, when the swelling over her cheekbone fades. During morning meeting, she sees someone familiar in the window of the classroom door. When their eyes meet, Ms. Torres' frown relaxes, and the worry drops from her face. It makes something untangle in Catra's chest. She waves, small, and Ms. Torres waves back.

Second grade, March

Eight years, one month

"You'll get it," Adora says, for the hundredth time. "You just need more practice, I'll help."

Catra picks up one of the strips that used to be her worksheet off their bedroom floor. Adora frowns as Catra shreds it thinner.

"Spelling is dumb," Catra says, "and practicing is dumber."

Adora's frustrated jaw sets. "If you don't try, you'll definitely need a signature."

Catra drops her failed spelling quizzes in the trash outside the school building as soon as she can, now. When Ms. Jackson asks for her test back, Catra says they got lost, and Ms. Jackson didn't even buy that the first time. That's one of a million reasons why Catra never has enough stars on her chart at the end of the week to fish some stupid toy out of Ms. Jackson's treasure box of plastic slinkies and hot dog erasers, but that's still better than proving what a failure she is.

Catra makes her mouth move big, exaggerated. "I. Don't. Care." She fishes out Adora's crayons and starts to draw in the back of her math workbook. "If you want to memorize my stupid words, go ahead. I have better things to do."

"Conferences are coming up," Adora says. "I don't want you to-" She stops right before Catra gets ready to shove her. "Just practice with me again. Please. One time. Then we can play whatever you want."

There's enough stress in Adora's voice for Catra to agree. They go through the list three more times before Catra remembers all the letters. *c-a-k-e, m-i-n-e, d-o-z-e-*

"Everyone has all ten written down, right?"

Catra blinks at the page. She has two.

"Make sure your name is on your quiz before you flip it," Ms. Jackson says. "I know you can spell that."

Everyone else at Catra's desk cluster flip their papers over, the way Ms. Jackson told them to when they were done with a test. Catra scribbles down anything she can remember. *tune, pile-*

"Time's up," Gabbie says from the desk across from her.

"Shut up," Catra snaps back. *woke, gave-*

"You can't keep writing after time's up, cheater."

"I said *shut up!*"

Catra's pencil drew a long line across her paper when she yelled, and everyone's looking at her now. Ms. Jackson says, "Catra," in the tone that means that she's being a brat again.

Stupid Gabbie still has a stupid smirk on her stupid face. Catra crushes her paper and throws it at her.

Gabbie throws it back. "Yeah, *Catra*," she says. "Don't go crazy again."

The desk crashes loud when Catra hits it. The other kids pull back, waiting for her to explode. "You little bitch." The words burn like stomach acid on her tongue. "If I hear anything else out of that fucking mouth-"

"*Catra,*" Ms. Jackson says, so loud that Catra's shoulders flinch. "That's enough."

Catra blinks through the water in her eyes. She shoves her chair out to get up. She's not going to sit in her seat with everyone staring at her, waiting to be taken away like the rotten animal she is. She knows where she's going. She's been there every day this week.

Ms. Torres has the door open by the time she rounds the corner, standing in the doorway, classroom phone cord stretched as far as she can. "Yes, I have her," she says into the phone. "Thank you."

Catra tries to slip past, and Ms. Torres lets her. She crashes on a beanbag hard, and it barely thuds out the fury hammering in her ears. She punches the bag and pretends that it's Gabbie's stupid face.

When her punches run out and Catra curls up on the bag instead, Ms. Torres says, "It's been a tough week, huh."

Yesterday, she argued with Penny about who got the only sharp blue colored pencil in their desk cluster and Ms. Jackson sent her to wait by the door when she tried to tear it out of Penny's hand. The day before that, Olly corrected her in small group and Ms. Torres came after Catra almost pushed his chair over.

The next time I get a call about you, Ms. Weaver said over dinner, while Catra watched Adora sneak green beans into her napkin, *I'll tell them to call the pound instead.* Adora kept glancing anxiously at the backyard door for a punishment that never happened. Catra almost wished she could go out into the snow again, where she couldn't hear anything, where everything went numb until she didn't care that she was probably going to die.

"You scared Ms. Jackson when you ran out," Ms. Torres says, sitting on the floor next to her. "She wants you to be safe, she cares about you. We all do. You have to stay with your class, friend, you know that."

One of the strands on the fuzzy cover is longer than the others. Catra tugs on it. "I fucking hate it here."

"We use nice words at school," Ms. Torres corrects, but there's no sharpness to it. "Why?"

The strand comes off in her hand. "'M too stupid to learn anything."

"Catra, that's not true." In the corner of her eye, Ms. Torres leans towards her. "You learn all the time, you're so smart."

Ms. Torres lies better than anyone Catra knows. The bald spot on the beanbag cover glares at her.

Ms. Torres stands, opens a drawer. "Do you want to learn something right now?"

Catra doesn't, but she sits up anyway. Ms. Torres holds a square of paper on the table, folding and refolding until she has something pointy and complicated. "It's a crane," she says. "I'll show you how to make one."

Catra thinks about the towering machines at the construction site by the grocery store. "Doesn't look like a crane," she says. "Looks hard."

"Cranes are a kind of bird. See the wings?" Ms. Torres slides a piece of purple paper in front of her. "You can do it. I believe in you."

Catra rips the first try when her folds are crooked, and the second, and the third. But eventually, Ms. Torres sets her little crane next to Catra's, and through the wrinkles and uneven wings, they look like they're trying to be the same thing.

"Let's do one more, then you go back to class," Ms. Torres says, giving Catra a yellow piece of paper. Catra folds slow and careful, and by the time Ms. Torres helps her bloom out the wings, the angry thunderstorm in her chest has settled.

"Here," Ms. Torres says, handing the crane back. "You can take it home."

Catra shakes her head. Things get broken at home. Things last here. "Keep it," she says.

"I think it's amazing," Ms. Torres tells her, and it has to be a lie like it always is. Catra wants to believe it anyway.

Ms. Torres puts the bird on the magnet board, pinned up by a wing. When Catra takes out her homework that night, there's a

different crane in her backpack, creased by sharp nails, only a little squished under her folders.

Adora crowds in to look. "What's that?"

"A crane," Catra says. "It's a kind of bird. My - my friend made it."

Adora says something nice about how great it is that Catra has friends in her room, now that they're in different classes. Catra fiddles with the wings until she figures out how to make the bird flat again, and she puts it deep in her math book, where no one else will ever find it.

Third grade, October

Eight years, six months

Ms. Torres' voice is low and urgent. "Check again."

"I don't know what to tell you," the school nurse says. Catra shifts the ice pack on her cast. It still feels like someone's hammering on her arm, driving in a nail, but the ice pushes the pain a little further away. "I don't have the form. And I've never had this parent authorize anything over the phone, for either kid. She just picks 'em up."

Catra knew this was going to happen, which is why she argued when Ms. Knowles said she was going to call Ms. Torres to take her to the nurse, after Catra gave up trying to pay attention and tucked her head against her desk. *You're not in trouble,* Ms. Knowles lied, while Catra rubbed at the smudges on her cast and thought about how many things she'd throw if she wasn't so fucking tired, if her arm didn't pound deeper than bone.

It didn't hurt this much at the hospital. The nurses there put tubes in her arms, and whatever they pumped through that had made everything fuzzy and dizzy and numb. By the time the doctor had to touch her arm to put the bones back where they should be, Catra could only feel the spot on her other shoulder where Ms. Weaver's hand sat.

You're being very brave, one of the hospital nurses said, when she didn't cry.

Ms. Torres makes a quiet sound of frustration. "Look at her. Ice isn't remotely adequate."

"I feel for the kid, I do, but the district requires authorization for a reason. I can't just hand out meds. If something goes wrong, that's on my head. But thanks for bringing her in, I'll handle the phone call."

"No," Ms. Torres says, "I'll take care of that."

Maybe if Ms. Torres had been here yesterday, Catra wouldn't have scratched and screamed at Tomas when he grabbed at her new cast, and maybe she would have stayed at school and learned about compasses instead of going home. Halfway through her punishment, the broken pieces of arm screamed loud enough to make her sick on the kitchen floor. Catra could still taste it through the chalky grape flavor of the medicine Adora stole, after Ms. Weaver had gone to bed.

Adora stayed awake until the medicine worked enough to let Catra sleep, brushing the hair off of her sticky face. *She didn't mean to,* Adora whispered over the sound of the cars outside. *She just got too mad. I'll help you listen better, and then she won't get mad at all.*

Footsteps, and then Ms. Torres is sitting next to her. She gestures to the ice pack. Her smile feels fake. "Is that helping?"

Catra nods. "It's okay now," she says, and if she doesn't look at Ms. Torres, she doesn't have to make her face match. She's tired.

She's going to be tired forever. "I can go back to class."

"Not yet," Ms. Torres says.

They return to the decompression room, and Catra flops on her favorite bean bag in the corner. It's fuzzy and purple, with blue swirls that she can feel when she closes her eyes. She faces the wall so Ms. Torres won't know what a pathetic crybaby she is.

It's been more than a week since her arm broke. She got medicine last night. She has a cast, and ice. She should be better by now.

"Hey, Catra," Ms. Torres says from behind her, quiet. "Can you swallow pills?"

Catra will do anything Ms. Torres wants from her, so she nods. There's a tap on her good hand, and when she opens it, something small slips inside. The pill is orange, smooth.

Catra's voice crackles when she talks. "Nurse said no medicine."

Ms. Torres puts a water bottle next to her. From the corner of her eye, Catra sees her slip the medicine container back in her purse. "It's okay. Go ahead and take it, and then I'll get out whatever activity you want, deal? The kinetic sand is new."

The pill scratches her throat, but it goes down. Catra digs her good hand through the rice bin, burying and digging up zoo animals, looping her fingers in circles. Her brain stops sticking on her arm as the pain fades, and when Ms. Torres asks again if she's feeling better, Catra doesn't have to lie.

The pain comes back later, like it always does. The next morning, Ms. Torres pulls her out of breakfast for more. It's the chewable kind this time, like Adora gets out of the medicine cabinet. Ms. Torres comes back the next day, and the next day. Catra keeps nodding for them long past the day that the ache in her arm dies. They make something else feel better, something that eases as soon as the tablet touches her palm.

Third grade, May

Nine years, three months

Catra's having a bad day. Her shirt itches, she didn't get to bed until long after Lonnie had fallen asleep, and instead of Ms. Knowles, they have a substitute who says her name wrong.

It's so hot in the classroom today. Ms. Knowles gave refillable water bottles to Catra and Lonnie and the other kids who didn't have their own when it started getting hot enough to open the windows, but Catra's cracked when she threw it on the floor last week and there isn't another. Drips of sweat crawl on her skin like little bugs.

Catra has a page of math problems, and the other kids at her desk cluster are almost done with theirs but she isn't because she can't think, brain broken and useless. The numbers keep turning in her head, twisting, and as soon as she writes an answer down, she's sure it's wrong. *Barely good for one thing,* Ms. Weaver said last night.

The substitute says it's time for recess. Catra didn't pay attention when she wrote her name on the board, and it's gone now. The sub tells everyone to hand in their worksheets, and dumb Lonnie is bringing her paper to the dumb substitute because of course she's done, she's not a stupid worthless piece of-

"You, my friend," the sub says, locking eyes with Catra, "can sit on the side until you've redone that work." Catra's worksheet is shredded in her hands, wrenched between her fingers. "Now line up before I make it all recess."

Her chair knocks over when she stands up. She shouts *shut up!* so loud that maybe the principal can hear her, maybe Ms. Knowles

can hear her from wherever she decided was more important than Class 302 today.

Ms. Knowles doesn't take recess away, and she definitely wouldn't over something so stupid. Recess is when Catra gets to climb and run as fast as she wants. Adora's at recess. It's not fair. It's not *fucking fair* and Catra slams her hands on her desk hard enough to make the scraps of paper jump.

The other kids scurry to the door, stare at her with bug eyes like they always do. They're probably whispering about how much trouble Catra's going to be in, how long she'll be buried alive, how pathetic she looks when she screams and begs for it to stop-

Catra shoves over another chair.

"Relax," Lonnie says, over Catra's crying. Catra doesn't know when that started. She slams herself into the bookshelf, hard and loud, but it still doesn't crack her open far enough to let the poison out.

Ms. Knowles always takes the class into the hall when Catra gets eaten up by how mad she is, but this sub walks up to the next desk cluster and says, "Stop this now before I send you home."

Catra yells, wordless. Those aren't the rules. She didn't hurt anyone, she gets to take a break and try again later, they can't make her leave if she didn't do anything - she *didn't do anything-*

The door slams shut, and Catra jolts. She's alone. There's a chair in her hand and she doesn't remember picking it up. She throws the chair hard on the floor, but that doesn't get rid of the sick feeling in her stomach. She runs behind Ms. Knowles' desk and wedges under it as tight as she can. Her breath still storms.

Catra always wants Adora when she isn't there, but now it's worse, something tearing in her chest. Adora would hug her and say it's okay and Catra could pretend she isn't lying.

The door opens and closes gentle. "Catra," Ms. Torres says, "come out."

Catra's still crying. She doesn't think she ever stopped. She's good at being quiet, but Ms. Torres can always hear her.

Ms. Torres sits down across from where Catra's deep in the desk. She inhales, deep and loud. "Breathe, friend. Can you blow out some candles for me?"

Catra slams the side of her fist into the wood of the desk instead. "Don't want to go home," she manages, thick and choked.

Ms. Torres plants a hand on the floor, shoulders falling, head dipping. "Catra, honey," she says, "you hit a teacher with a chair. That's a big deal."

Ms. Weaver doesn't just pick her up today. There's a meeting after school, with the vice principal and Ms. Torres and the bitch sub, who shows Ms. Weaver the bruise on her arm like it's the worst fucking thing to happen to anyone. Catra wants to show her how messed up she would be if Catra was big enough to really hurt her.

The vice principal says she's suspended for a week, a whole *week* of pulling threads out of the rug and running away in her head, and she can't stop the moan that comes out of her mouth, the *no no no*that gasps through her lips. The tears come back. She can't feel the grip on her wrist.

"This kind of conduct is unacceptable, Catra," Mr. Graham says, because he hates her and wants her to die. "You're lucky Mrs. Simmons doesn't want to press charges. There still have to be consequences."

"Trust me," Ms. Weaver says, "there will be consequences at home too."

A week later, there's more wrong with her than usual. Ms. Knowles' smile is fake when she sees her, asks how she's doing,

and Catra sits sullen and silent at her desk and thinks about Ms. Knowles with a bruise on her instead. Everything's too loud, too bright, too much after picking at peeling wallpaper edges for days, and Catra feels like she hasn't slept in months.

When the music starts and everyone else picks a game to play, Catra puts her head on her desk. Ms. Knowles leans down next to her. "It's the last day of school," she says. "I'm not going to make you do the party if you don't feel up to it. You can go down the hall, or you can stay here with us. Tell me what you need."

Catra needs to be something better, some*one*. Part of her spilled out on the floor and hasn't come back. She doesn't know if it ever will.

Ms. Knowles hands Catra a hall pass, even though she didn't answer. The decompression room is still lit soft by vinyl sheets over the lights, and Ms. Torres lets her drag the playdough tray to the corner with the cold radiator, where she can put her back to the wall and squish purple through her fingers until her skin stains. It hides the red dried deep in the sides of her nails.

Catra snaps awake when the bell rings. Ms. Torres is talking to some older kid at the table, but the boy is leaving by the time Catra figures out where she is. The buses are already outside. The playdough is crusty and dry, caked on her hands.

"Good morning," Ms. Torres says, scooping what's left of the playdough into a bag and handing Catra a wet wipe. "Feeling better?"

Catra doesn't know how she feels, besides tired. She thinks she slept a lot over the last week. Time turned into a void, and the dark was the only thing that felt real. The scab on her leg, where she scratched until it bled, itches.

"Okay," Ms. Torres says, when Catra doesn't answer. Her mouth smiles, but her eyes keep frowning as she zips the bag closed.

"Can I walk you to the bus, friend? It looks like your sisters are out already."

Adora has her hands cupped around her face, pressed against the window, trying to see through the one-way film on the glass. Lonnie's there too, looking at her book. Adora always waits for Catra when she's late, but Lonnie never does.

Catra's been waiting for summer. At the daycare program, she doesn't have homework and grades, she doesn't have to stay in her seat, and no one makes her pay attention when she doesn't want to. There's only one class for all the big kids, so she gets to read books and play games and make up adventures with Adora all day long. They're outside for hours. She loves summer.

"Yeah," Catra says. Her voice scratches. She should be happy, but something else wells up like blood instead.

Ms. Torres looks at the bag of playdough in her hands, then holds it out. "Do you want to keep this?"

Catra nods, and now her throat hurts for a different reason. Ms. Torres makes a surprised sound when Catra hugs her, but she hugs back. She's a lot bigger than Adora is.

"Thanks," Catra says. Ms. Torres says something she can feel more than hear.

Ms. Torres lets go when she does. She clears her throat. "C'mon, friend," she says. "Summer's waiting."

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

All tags and warnings still apply.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Fourth grade, September

Nine years, seven months

The other kids stare when Ms. Torres holds her and won't let her loose. The fall wind blows her hair into her face, and it stings her scraped knuckles almost as much as the brick.

Catra doesn't want to be there. She doesn't want to be anywhere else, either. She wishes the arms around her would twist her head to break her neck like Josie says they do in movies. She wants to get up high enough to pop like a water balloon when she slams into the pavement.

Every inch of her says *quiet, quiet,* but someone's shouting like a siren. Catra tries to drive her elbow into the person behind her, but their grip gets tighter. She cracks, insides flowing out slippery and formless. Her eyes, ears, skin turn off. She doesn't need them while her body isn't hers.

Catra blinks, and she's not on the playground anymore. She's lying down on a gray beanbag, fur under her fingers. Her brain scans fast, but all of her clothes are where she left them.

"How do your hands feel?" Ms. Torres asks quietly.

They don't hurt enough. She should have hit the wall harder. "Fine," Catra rasps. Her throat aches, but the yelling kind. She thinks she was yelling. The other thing never happens here.

"I know you don't like it when we have to do this," Ms. Torres says. "I don't like it either. But you're not allowed to hurt yourself, Catra. We have to keep you safe."

Catra's so fucking sick of hearing that, like safe is something she should want. Safe is walking in the halls, keeping her feet on the floor, staying in her seat on the bus. It's following directions and being good and shutting up, and whatever part of Catra that's supposed to be able to do all that doesn't work.

Ms. Torres sighs next to her. "What's going on today, friend?"

"Everyone's stupid," Catra mutters into the fuzzy fabric. It's less scratchy than carpet. "Hate everything."

"Why were you hitting the wall?"

She couldn't keep pacing the yard with no one to talk to and nothing to do, because Adora has a different recess block this year and Lonnie hates her and the other kids won't let her use the balls or jump ropes anymore. The sun was out, chill seeping through her sweatshirt that doesn't cover her wrists, but she might as well still be downstairs, imagining escape. She's never going to be human and she's going to be this awful thing forever and if she didn't hit something she was going to explode.

Catra pulls her legs in tighter. "It doesn't matter."

Ms. Torres tilts her head. "Is this about Parent Night?"

No. That was yesterday, and Catra didn't care anyway. She went on the stage and lined up in her spot and sang the dumb song. She stood still while Ms. Weaver told Adora what a beautiful job she did, and she ignored fucking Lonnie showing her fucking mom the whole school like anyone gives a shit.

Lonnie's mom wasn't even supposed to be there, Lonnie can't even live with her, but whatever idiot makes those decisions approved it, and Catra couldn't get far enough away from them to not hear all the *that's great, you're so smart, I'm so proud of you-*

"It's okay to miss your mom," Ms. Torres says, and she grabs Catra's arm before she can punch the floor.

Catra doesn't miss the woman who only said she loved her until she'd seen enough to know better. Catra's glad that she isn't going to find out how bad her mother's punishments would be, once she found out what a sick little slut Catra is. The dark clouds that choke her when she thinks about her mom are stupid.

"It's okay to be upset." Ms. Torres' voice is quiet, smooth. It doesn't sound like blame. "And whatever is going on with her, it isn't your fault."

Catra tries to hit the ground again, but Ms. Torres is still holding her arm. Catra hopes she never sees Camila Guerra again. Catra didn't search the crowd from the stage, and even if she did, it was just to make sure her mother wasn't there.

I'm surprised she stuck around that long, Ms. Weaver had said later, standing too close to put the pasta in to boil, thumb on the bone of Catra's hip like Adora's not doing hockey drills on the other side of the window. Ms. Weaver's been doing that more and more since she found the new dark hairs that Catra tried to pull out, the pebbles growing under Catra's shirt. Catra blinked into the steam and thought about how hot the water would be. *Even you can't have been stupid enough to think that she'd actually want you. Not off your back, anyway.*

She wants it to be a relief. Her mom was like a bad tangle, messy and knotted and painful to brush, and it was easier when Ms. Weaver cut it out and threw it away. When Adora came inside and found Catra hiding under Adora's bed, she crawled under with her, pet her hair until Catra could breathe well enough to tell her. *We don't need anybody but each other,* Adora said.

"Not calming me down," Catra forces between her teeth.

"I needed you to know that," Ms. Torres says. "If you breathe for me, I'll take down whatever calming activity you want. Deal?"

Catra's too old for imaginary flowers, but the exercises still work, especially after Ms. Torres puts the rice bin on the floor next to her and lets her drop in marbles to fish out. She's probably too old for that too, but sifting her hands through it feels like washing something away, and it makes her go quiet as an ocean with no waves. It makes her skin stop itching so bad she wants to take it off.

"Feeling better?" Ms. Torres asks. Ms. Torres isn't anyone's mom, but she'd be good at it. Catra definitely didn't look for her at Parent Night either.

Catra nods. She blinks at the prickle in her eyes. When she gets back to class, she makes tiny squares of her notebook paper and thinks about flying away.

At lunch later that week, Catra gets permission to go down the hall to the decompression room. Ms. Torres comes in before she can leave, and Catra grabs the gift off the table with her shaking hands. She shoves it behind her back too slow.

"Some idiot left trash in here," Catra says. "You should clean up better."

Ms. Torres' mouth twists, unhappy, and Catra tightens her shoulders for the yell and the angry hands. Ms. Torres smiles fake again and puts out a palm instead. "Can I see that?"

Catra tried so many sheets of paper, trying to make it perfect. It's crumpled now. But Ms. Torres straightens the crane's tail and says, "I hope this is for me, because I love it."

Ms. Torres is nice when she lies.

Fourth Grade, January

Nine years, eleven months

"What happened?" Ms. Torres asks in the hall on the way to Mr. Graham's office.

Catra drags her feet. She knows the expression on Ms. Torres' face without even looking. "Penny's a bitch and I'd hit her again."

"We use kind words at school," Ms. Torres says, automatic. "We've talked about this. What are you supposed to do if someone makes you angry?"

"Breathe. Count. Talk to a teacher." Catra's teeth scrape on the words. She's so fucking tired of breathing.

"Did you do any of those things?"

Ms. Torres knows she didn't. Penny laughed when saw the book report that Catra made up on the bus this morning, scribbled pencil and holes where there were bumps in the road, and Catra's fist went into Penny's gut twice before she even felt her hands ball up. It doesn't matter if she tries to do any of the stupid shit Ms. Torres wants her to do, because the rot finds a way out of her anyway.

"I know you're having a hard time right now," Ms. Torres says, once they're sitting outside the vice principal's office, "but you can't hurt people here. You know that."

"Shut up," Catra says, in a tone that would definitely get her in trouble with anyone else.

Ms. Torres sighs. She picks up one of the half-pages of paper on the table next to her, for kids to write resolutions on. She squares it off and hands it to Catra before taking another. Catra crushes her paper in her fist, but she watches Ms. Torres' hands flick through the folds until she has a flower in her palm.

When Ms. Weaver gets there, she holds Catra's arm tight enough that it's going to bruise later. "We're sensitive to her

circumstances," Mr. Graham says past Catra, "and we're being as flexible as we can with her other behaviors. But we can't tolerate violence for any reason."

"Of course not." Ms. Weaver's nails dent in Catra's skin. Catra wishes her own nails were still long enough to pop eyes.

On Friday morning, when Catra's suspension ends, she peels the gauze off her hands with a hiss she can't fight down. The shiny skin still bubbles, cotton coming away yellowed and wet where the red blotches ooze. She'd hoped that her fingers didn't move right because of the bandages, but they're still swollen and clumsy while she gets dressed.

"You look like shit," Lonnie says, when Catra tries to grab the tiny zipper pull on her sweatshirt. "You look *contagious*. You won't make it ten minutes."

Catra's hands are fucked, but her legs still kick just fine. "You won't make it five if you don't shut up."

She leaves the sweatshirt open, but she holds her hands careful in her pockets, and Ms. Weaver doesn't stop her from going out the door. Adora panics on the bus, when she sees them, but Adora panics about dumb stuff all the time. She doesn't understand that people will ignore anything if you pretend it looks worse than it is.

"They're going to make you go to the nurse," Adora says, "If I knew you weren't better, I wouldn't've let you-"

"I don't need the fucking nurse," Catra snaps. "I'm fine. Quit freaking out before I change seats."

Penny sits on the other side of the room now, and no one sits next to Catra. She has to use her teeth to take the wrap off her breakfast sandwich, but she got here. She's going to be okay.

Ms. Estevez stops by her desk. "What happened?"

"Nothing," Catra says, and it isn't until Ms. Estevez frowns that she realizes that Lonnie and Adora were right.

Catra tries to curl her hands into fists and the skin stretching over her knuckles makes her gag. "They're fine. They don't even hurt, my mom put medicine on them, they're *fine*-"

"Catra." Ms. Estevez uses the voice for when she wants a kid to look at her, and Catra doesn't. "You can go to the nurse by yourself, or I can call Ms. Torres to take you."

Thinking about disappointing Ms. Torres again makes her eyes sting. "No. Just let me eat, this is so stupid, it-"

Catra's going to cry and the whole class is watching. She's an idiot. Kennedy is staring from the desk across from her, and if Catra's hands worked she could grab her hair, force her eyes away, hit her head on the desk hard enough to make her face shut up. Catra should have stayed home and hid under her bed so she didn't dig herself another grave, but now Ms. Weaver will pour the bleach down her throat so it can eat her empty insides.

The door cracks against the wall when she throws it open. The hand that grabbed the doorknob screams as loud as Catra wants to, and one of the blisters on her palm is flat and wet now. She's not running fast enough for her heart to beat this hard.

An arm snags Catra's shoulder and she jerks away, dizzy. "Catra," Ms. Torres says. They're outside the decompression room. Catra doesn't know how she got here.

Ms. Torres glances down and breathes in sharp. "What happened?"

Can't be fucking trusted with these, Ms. Weaver said, holding Catra's hands down as the stinging gets worse, fumes choking like smoke. *You won't be the kind of whore who needs them anyway.*

"Nothing," Catra says, hoarse, useless. She shoves her hands into her armpits and wishes she could cut them off. "It was an

accident, I didn't mean to, it's fine. Don't make me go."

Ms. Torres looks at her, and for a moment Catra thinks that maybe she has a box like Ms. Weaver has, with cream and gauze and the stiff things for big cuts. Maybe she'll let Catra sit on something soft, and she'll smooth something cool over Catra's scorching skin and she won't say *you know exactly why this happened* while she does.

Ms. Torres bends her knees so her face is easier to see. "I'm not sending you home. We'll get you help together, okay?"

Catra closes her eyes and thinks about falling out of windows and puddling on the ground, or getting crushed under car wheels. It feels more peaceful than scary.

She doesn't answer any of the nurse's questions, and she tries not to react when the nurse's gloved hands touch her skin. It doesn't seem to matter anymore that Ms. Weaver didn't sign the form, because the nurse pulls out the packet of medicine right away. "You have to chew both of these," the nurse says.

When Catra shakes her head, Ms. Torres crouches next to her. "It's going to make your hands feel better."

"They don't hurt."

Anger flares loud on Ms. Torres' face, and Catra braces for her to grab, scratch, crush the blisters until Catra's finally quiet.

Ms. Torres says, "I have to go talk to someone, but I'm coming back, alright? It's going to be okay."

The nurse's gloved fingers put chalk to her lips, and Catra doesn't fight the way her muscles slump at the pressure. It doesn't matter. She's dead anyway. When Ms. Torres comes back to tell her that her social worker is on her way, she doesn't even look sorry.

Ms. Torres looks sorry on Monday, after Catra comes back to school with a doctor's note for her cleaning accident and a deeper void in her chest. Catra should give her a mark like Lonnie's, where Catra bit the snitch as soon as she got the chance. But Ms. Torres lets her pick which new affirmation cards should go on the board, so maybe she's not as bad as Lonnie.

Fifth grade, August

Ten years, six months

Catra's stomach thuds aching and hollow. The waffle and carton of milk that were in her breakfast bag this morning only make it worse. Lonnie dropped her milk half-full on Catra's desk on her way to the trash, but Catra's still looking at her pencil instead of the board and imagining it crunching between her teeth.

She shouldn't have tried to sneak down to the kitchen in the first place. She knows better. She should be glad that she only got two handfuls of orange crackers in her mouth before Ms. Weaver caught her, so she had less to vomit into the sink when Ms. Weaver dug down her throat.

Don't know why I'm fucking surprised anymore, Ms. Weaver said, when Catra's retches finally came up empty. *Whore like your mother. Thief like her too.*

"Catra," Mrs. Dalton says, and the giggles mean that it's not the first time she's called her name. "It's your turn."

There's a timeline on the whiteboard. They do Language Arts first.

"Can you tell us what happened after Trisha swam with the turtles?"

The other kids have *The Wildest Summer* out. Catra barely remembers being handed a copy. She definitely doesn't remember opening it.

"We're going through some of the major events in the narrative," Mrs. Dalton says, in the tone that means she's trying not to sound as exasperated as she is. "Can you tell us about any major event from the book?"

No, and Mrs. Dalton should know better than to ask her. Quinn's smirking in the next desk cluster, stupid bitch with stupid perfect hair who probably never has to scrub puke out of a kitchen sink in the middle of the night and think about how the cleaning spray would taste and wonder how long it would take to die.

"Let's come back to you," Mrs. Dalton says. "Jameel, can you-"

"Trisha opens a wormhole to swallow up her shithole school," Catra says, loud enough that Mrs. Dalton has to hear it.

The giggling is more shocked this time. Across from Quinn, Lonnie rolls her eyes. "Jameel," Mrs. Dalton says, like Catra doesn't even exist, "what can you tell us about-"

"And all the stupid fucking turtles get crushed," Catra says, and then Mrs. Dalton looks at her. "Into mush."

Mrs. Dalton gestures to the door. "Take the hall pass. I'm not making Casta come for you again, you know how to get there."

Catra's eyes sting. Part of her wants to refuse to leave, *make* Ms. Torres come for her. Part of her is already down the hall. She slams her chair after she gets up, slams the classroom door shut behind her, slams into one of the plastic chairs on the floor of the decompression room.

"Good morning," Ms. Torres says from the magnet board. Catra's math review quiz is still on there, from the first week of class, when she got 92% and brought it down during lunch to brag about it. There's hours until lunch.

Catra snatches one of the cereal cups from the bucket on Ms. Torres' desk. She forgets that she's supposed to get milk from the other bucket until she's halfway through, shoveling with her hands to get the cornflakes in her mouth faster. Ms. Torres doesn't say that Catra's eating like a wild fucking animal and maybe she should go live with them instead. She just finishes cleaning the board.

"I hate Mrs. Dalton," Catra says, when the plastic is empty in her hands, probably too late to be convincing.

Ms. Torres throws the paper towel away before she sits down at the table. "Why?"

Catra takes another cup. She's eating slow enough to taste this one, so she has time to think of a reason. "She knows I didn't read the dumb book. She's only asking because she wants to make me look stupid."

Ms. Torres looks at her computer and types something. "Do you think-"

"Don't take notes on me," Catra mumbles around the cornflakes.

Ms. Torres glances over. "What makes you think that's what I'm doing?"

There was a worker who sat in the corner of the visitation room last summer, back when Catra's mom pretended she wanted her. The worker scribbled about every awkward conversation Catra's mother tried to have with her, every toy her mom picked up that Catra had outgrown years ago, every time her mom started sobbing and saying *I'm so sorry baby, I'm trying, please look at me-*

"I'm not an idiot," Catra says.

"I have to do paperwork for everyone who comes here," Ms. Torres says, "which of course includes you. But none of these forms go home."

They go to Ms. Milagros, though. She mentions it every time Catra sees her, including last week. *You have to be able to behave if you want to grow up to live anywhere but prison,* Ms. Milagros says. *You should understand that better than most kids.*

Catra tenses her feet in her shoes instead of gritting her teeth. Even with milk, the cereal is too dry in her mouth.

Ms. Torres pauses, and says, "You remember that you can come here before the bell, right? This is all here before nine, and I know you're on an early bus. You don't need to act up to eat when you're hungry."

"I'm not hungry," Catra snarls through the food in her mouth. It's hard to swallow around the lump in her throat. "It's not my fucking fault that this school gives us a tiny nothing breakfast. I'm growing. It's normal."

"School-appropriate language," Ms. Torres says, but her tone's still warm. "You're not in trouble, Catra. I just wanted to make sure you remembered."

Ms. Torres has the dumb turtle book. She says she found it half-under the radiator, in the corner Catra puts to her back when she can't breathe with anything else behind her. It must have fallen out of her bag when she had to be picked up early last week. "I'll save you a spot in the morning and you can work on it," Ms. Torres says, brown eyes smiling.

"Well, now I won't come," Catra says, but she holds the book careful back to her classroom and makes sure it goes in her backpack. There are other kids there the next day, but Ms. Torres lets Catra take her apple and cereal bar to her corner, and the food washes away the metallic taste in her mouth when Ms. Torres talks nice to the other kids too.

Fifth grade, June

Eleven years, four months

Catra stays in her chair after Ms. Milagros leaves. She hears the door open and close, but she doesn't look up. She picks at the scab on the back of her wrist until it starts to bleed. She can't feel it.

A bandaid taps her arm. "Here," Ms. Torres said, and Catra lets her cover the scrape even though she's old enough to do it herself.

When she's done, Ms. Torres stays crouched next to Catra's fuzzy chair. "What happened?"

Catra shoves away the blank sheet of paper in front of her. It floats to the floor frustratingly slow.

"An apology," she grinds out. "She wants me to write an apology."

In the corner of her eye, Ms. Torres frowns. "To who?"

"To Ms. Weaver. For lying." Catra's skin feels too tight. "But I didn't even-"

The pencil hits the wall before Catra thinks to throw it. "I didn't!" The rage bubbles up hot. "Someone told her shit I didn't fucking say. I didn't do it, I didn't!"

And now Ms. Milagros is going to tell Ms. Weaver that Catra told someone the bruising that wraps under her long sleeves to her chest and her hips isn't from fighting Lonnie, and as soon as Catra walks in the door she's going to be in trouble again, and she's going to break her own fucking head open on the basement wall.

"Catra," Ms. Torres says in her stupid gentle voice, the *let me help* voice, and it's such bullshit because no one's going to help her, she doesn't get help, there's no way to help unless Ms. Torres can

turn her into something other than a stupid fucking piece of shit that just needs to-

"Breathe," Ms. Torres says.

Catra slams her chair into the wall, where it rips papers off the magnet board. She shoves the table, crashes the cups of pencils and crayons to the floor. She throws toys by the handful until the basket is empty, and then she throws that too.

She gasps in the wreckage, and realizes that Ms. Torres hasn't come near her, hasn't stopped her even though she's definitely 'a danger to her environment.' She sits down hard. Even her legs are sick of her.

Ms. Torres comes down with her. She holds out a bottle of water, like she doesn't think Catra's going to immediately smash it. Catra tries not to think about how much she'll want water, later, so she doesn't throw up before she drinks it.

Catra puts the bottle down when her stomach hurts worse. Ms. Torres is looking at her with a familiar twist to her face. "Feeling better?" Ms. Torres asks.

Catra nods, though that's barely true. Another piece of paper falls from the magnet board. The only good place, and she ruined it. "Sorry," she says. She's too old for tantrums. "I'll - I'll fix it."

"We'll clean up in a minute," Ms. Torres says. "But I want you to know that you don't owe anyone else an apology right now. For anything."

Catra swallows, nods.

"And that, um." Ms. Torres pauses long. "You're a really great kid."

It's good that Catra finished drinking. At least when Ms. Torres lies, she's funny.

"Listen. You are. And none of this," Ms. Torres gestures around them, "means that you deserve for anyone to treat you badly. You deserve better than that. Do you understand?"

Catra squeezes the water bottle until the plastic crunches. There are way worse things about her than this mess. "I know," she says, before Ms. Torres has a chance to find those things. Catra looks at the clock. "I need to go to lunch," she says.

They clean up quick. Ms. Torres picks up the sheet of paper Ms. Milagros tore out of her notebook and balls it up before she throws it away.

"Enjoy your lunch," Ms. Torres says when Catra leaves. "I think it's pizza today."

Catra's out sick for most of the next week, and she's laser-focused on not getting in trouble when she gets back so she doesn't miss graduation. When her class goes to gym, Ms. Torres passes in the hall, holding the hand of a little kid with a mottled angry face, and she gives the class a smile that Catra likes to think was meant for her.

First grade, November

Twenty-eight years, nine months

Huntara said it had been a good day for Finn. Adora had been worrying for the last week leading up to her training course in Dryl - including this morning, if the anxious text Catra got when she woke up was anything to go by - but they'd all be fine. Catra knew they'd be fine.

"Okay," she reviews, once Finn has buckled themself in and is making eye contact in the rearview mirror. "We're going to the

park to see your mom, then we're getting ice cream, and then we're going home. Adora's still at her training, but she'll call tonight, like we talked about this morning. We good?"

Finn matches her thumbs-up, hugging their weighted ankylosaurus to their chest. Adora helped them name it Kyle, because she thinks she's funny. "We painted leaves in art today," they chirp. "I did a bunch of yellow for Mom. And I want to show Adora too."

Catra was prepared to hate Finn's mom, but she doesn't. She gets the same vertigo she feels seeing Scorpia with Flora and Briar, Naomi with any of her kids, or Lonnie and the boys with Imp. Her therapist says someday it won't feel strange to see parents caring anymore.

Catra shifts the car into gear. "That's great, buddy. I think they'll both really like it."

Finn's craning their neck when they pull into the parking lot. Their mom's always at the picnic table by the water fountain, and when the table's empty, Catra's stomach starts to drop even before she sees the text she missed two hours ago.

I'm so sorry, I can't be there today. Can we reschedule for tomorrow? Tell Finn I love them.

Finn's already undone the buckles on their car seat when Catra turns around. "Hold on a sec, pal."

They pause, leaf picture clenched in a fist that tightens in the moment Catra takes to figure out how to say this. Probably a good parent would say *you'll see Mom tomorrow, this will never happen again, everything's okay*. Louder than that is the decades-old *so she's finally seen what a nightmare you are and moved on.*

Catra settles on, "Mom isn't here today, Finn. We can still-"

Finn yanks on the door handle and bolts.

They both go down when Catra catches them, a hundred feet into the grass. Finn kicks, arms flailing, howling. The paper hits her in her face. Catra forces shaky breaths, holding them tighter.

"Finn," she says, over the panic. A car passes on the road that's way too close. "Finn, stop!"

They smack their head against her collarbone, and Catra shifts to press their head against her chest while the rest of her keeps them down. "Liar!" Finn screams, and it vibrates through them both.

In one-two-three-four. Catra just holds onto her kid and breathes and wishes Dryl wasn't so fucking far away.

When Finn finally slumps into tears and Catra can adjust them to settle in her arms, she's ready to cry with them. "Finn, you can't run away from me like that," Catra says, and hopefully they can't hear the shake in her voice. "The road's right there. I don't want you to get hit."

"Hate you," Finn sobs into your shirt. "Want Ms. Adora."

Catra exhales slow enough to keep from losing her shit. If she was a better parent, she'd probably be most upset about Finn reverting to titles. "Me too."

Despite what Finn said, they push against her rib cage like they're trying to climb inside it. "You lied. You said Mom was here."

"I thought she would be." Catra lifts one of her hands off Finn's back, and when they don't try to tear away, she runs it through their golden hair. It's getting longer on the side they want to grow out. "I didn't see what she sent me, I'm sorry. Look, I'll show you, okay?"

Thank god she'd shoved her phone in her pocket before everything went to shit. Finn can't read much, but they always want to try. "See," Catra says, unlocking the screen and pointing to the text. "That word's 'tell.' What's the next one?"

Finn sniffs against her chest. "Finn," they read. Catra moves her finger to the next word. "I. Love. Them."

"I wish she was here too, kid, but sometimes things happen. She wants to try again another day." Catra isn't repeating this tomorrow. It usually works best when Finn knows the schedule in advance, but she'll run the risk of a dysregulated evening after a surprise visit if it means Finn won't try to take off again. "Your mom loves you. I love you. And-"

She swipes to the next text thread. Adora thought that Finn might feel betrayed that she's away, and Catra was insistent that they understand. Maybe they don't understand as well as she'd thought. Under Adora's worry and Catra's reassurance, Adora sent emojis back: a cat and a heart, a fish and a heart.

"What does that mean, Finn?"

They shift when they recognize Adora's code. "Heart for you," Finn murmurs. "Heart for me."

"Means Adora loves us, right?" Catra swallows. Dryl is really far away. "Lots of people love you, and we'd all be very, very sad if something happened to you. So you can't run like that again. You really scared me."

"Sorry," Finn says, and even if it's reflexive, it's something. "And I - I lied too. I don't hate you."

"We match, then, because I don't hate you either." Catra strokes their hair. In the corner of her eye, she can see Finn's open car door. She doesn't know why the fuck the safety lock wasn't on. Catra's door is probably open too - hopefully she didn't drop the keys.

"Okay," Catra says. "We're going to breathe, and when we're ready, there's wipes and water in the car. Do you still want to play in the park for a bit or go straight to ice cream?"

"Wanna go home." Finn fidgets with the collar of her work polo. "Wanna make dinosaurs."

Finn has been helping her fold models to put in their bedroom. Catra likes their rumpled attempts at iguanodons better than hers.

"Sounds like a plan, kid. Can you show me some flowers and candles first?"

Catra had forgotten those breathing exercises until Finn tried to explain, after a panicked meltdown, what Ms. Torres had taught them. They can do them by themself, now.

Catra makes sure that the fucking safety lock switch in the door is flipped when she loads Finn back in the car. They want to buckle themselves in again - they were so proud of themself when they figured out how to do that. Looking at Finn in the rearview mirror, shoving away the image of them crushed under tires, Catra says, "I'm sorry I had to tackle you out there, okay? You're still in charge of your own body, but that was dangerous and you could have gotten really hurt. I had to keep you safe."

Finn drags Kyle onto their lap. "You sound like Ms. Torres."

Catra clicks the car into gear, something coiling warm in her chest. "Thanks, Finn," she says. "I try."

Chapter End Notes

> *Now* they can rest. Thank you to everyone who helps make a difference for people who really need it - even if you can't see how you're helping, the difference is there. And thank you all for reading, I'll be back at some point with the other projects that are in the works. Take care yourselves ❤️

End Notes

Thank you for reading ❤ New chapter next week. I am not always able to reply to comments, but I treasure every one.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!